

CHAPTER SEVENTEEN

Forgiving Is Not the Same as Trusting

This chapter is going to be careful. Read it slowly.

There is a kid in this story we have not talked about much. Her name is Kezia, and she lives with her grandmother, which we know because Kezia told everyone on the first day of school. What we have not told you yet is why Kezia lives with her grandmother.

We are not going to tell you in detail. That is Kezia's story, and she will tell it when she is ready, in some later book, or in some private conversation as a grown-up that nobody else will hear. What we will tell you is this: there is a grown-up in Kezia's life who used to be a regular part of her family, and who is not a regular part of her family anymore, because the grown-up did some things that hurt Kezia and her grandmother, and the grown-up has not been allowed in their house for almost two years.

The grown-up keeps wanting to come back.

The grown-up sends cards on birthdays. The grown-up calls sometimes on the phone. The grown-up has said sorry, in many different ways, across two years.

Kezia's grandmother has said no every time.

Kezia, who is six and loves both her grandmother and the grown-up, has been confused about this for a long time. Her

grandmother has tried to explain, in age-appropriate words: I forgive them. But that does not mean they can come back. Forgiveness and trust are not the same. Kezia has not understood. She has understood the words, but not the shape of the words.

Today, in February, the lesson in Room 12 is going to give Kezia the shape of the words.

Mr. Tate is in the back of the room again. He has been in the back of the room for two lessons now. The kids know, by this point, that when Mr. Tate is in the back of the room, the lesson is going to be a big one. "Friends," said Sammy. "Today we are going to talk about two words that get used together, but that are NOT the same. Forgiveness. And trust."

Sammy held up the anchor chart.

FORGIVENESS TRUST

Inside you Between people For YOUR peace For SAFETY
You can give it alone The other person has to earn it A gift you
give yourself Never owed "Forgiveness," said Sammy, "is
INSIDE you. It is something you do for your own peace. You do
not need the other person's permission. You do not need them
to ask for it. You can just decide, in your own heart, to put the
weight down."

"Trust," said Sammy, "is BETWEEN people. It is about safety.
About whether you are going to let somebody close again.
Trust is not the same as forgiveness. Trust is earned. Trust
takes time. Trust has to be PROVED, over and over, by
changed behavior."

Sammy paused. Then Sammy said the most important
sentence of the lesson, and Ms. Calloway said it at the same
time, both of them, so that the kids would hear it in two
voices:

You can forgive someone — AND still choose not to be close to them. That is not mean. That is wise.

Kezia was sitting very still on the carpet.

"AND," said Sammy, "here is the part that grown-ups sometimes forget to tell kids. You are NEVER required to forgive someone who is STILL hurting you. If somebody is still being mean to you. If somebody is still doing the thing. Forgiveness is not for that situation. Forgiveness is for AFTER. For when the thing is over. For when you are SAFE. If you are not safe — you do not need to forgive. You need to be safe first. Safe comes first. Always. Always."

Ms. Calloway repeated it: Safe comes first. Always.

Mr. Tate, from the back of the room, nodded once.

Kezia raised her hand.

"Yes, Kezia?"

"Ms. Calloway? My grandma says we can forgive somebody and still not let them come over. Is that — that?"

"Yes, sweetheart. That is exactly that. Your grandma is doing the wise thing. She is choosing forgiveness for herself — for her own peace — but she is not giving back trust, because trust has to be earned, and the person has not done what it would take to earn it back. Your grandma is keeping you safe AND keeping her own peace. Those are two different jobs."

Kezia thought about this for a long time.

Then she said, very quietly: "I love them. And I do not want them to come over."

The room was quiet.

Ms. Calloway came over. She did not crouch this time. She sat down on the carpet next to Kezia.

"Kezia, my love. You can love somebody. And you can keep them out of your house. Those are not the same. Loving somebody is what is inside YOU. Whether they come over is a

different decision. Your grandma knows what is best for your safety. Loving them does not mean you have to be close to them. Loving them does not mean you have to be in danger. You can love them from a long way away, your whole life, and never be unsafe again."

Kezia put her head on Ms. Calloway's shoulder.

She did not cry. Kezia almost never cries. But she put her head on Ms. Calloway's shoulder for a long minute, and Ms. Calloway sat there with her, and Mr. Tate from the back of the room did not move, and Sammy went back into the box very quietly, and the rest of the kids did their quiet work without looking up.

When Kezia raised her head, she said: "I get it now. I get what Grandma was saying."

"Yes you do," said Ms. Calloway.

"Thank you, Ms. Calloway."

"Thank you, Kezia. For asking. That was a brave question."

Kezia went back to her seat.

After school, Ms. Calloway and Mr. Tate stood in the hallway for a few minutes, talking quietly. Mr. Tate said, "I am going to do a check-in with the grandmother this week, just to let her know how Kezia did today." Ms. Calloway said, "Yes. Please."

That night, Kezia's grandmother asked Kezia how school was.

"Good," said Kezia. "I understood something."

"What did you understand, baby?"

"I understood the thing about forgiving people but not letting them come over."

Kezia's grandmother put her tea down. Her eyes got a little shiny. "And what did you understand, baby?"

"That we can love them. And not let them come over. Both can be true."

Kezia's grandmother — who is a woman who has been carrying things in her own backpack for a very long time, and who has had to make some of the hardest decisions a grandmother can make to protect her grandchild — said, "Yes, baby. Both can be true. Both have to be true. That is the whole thing."

She hugged Kezia for a long time.

When Kezia went to bed that night, she felt a kind of quiet she had not felt in two years. She did not have words for it. But the feeling was: I am allowed to love them. AND I am allowed to be safe. I do not have to pick. She was six years old.

She fell asleep with that feeling.

Some lessons are not lessons. Some lessons are permissions.

This one was a permission.